

POLSCI 160: Introduction to World Politics

Education shall be directed to the full development of the human personality and to the strengthening of respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms. It shall promote understanding, tolerance and friendship among all nations, racial or religious groups, and shall further the activities of the United Nations for the maintenance of peace. — Universal Declaration of Human Rights, Article 26.2. [For the Full text of the UDHR see the 578 language translations.](#)

Course Information

- **Instructor:** Christopher J. Fariss. Learn more about my research and teaching here: <http://cfariss.com/>.
- **Classroom Location:** 1210 CHEM
- **Course Time:** Monday and Wednesday 4:00pm–5:20pm EST.
- **Instructor Office Hours:** Tuesday, 11:00am–12:30pm EST. Wednesday, 2:00pm–3:30pm EST. Institute for Social Research atrium. 426 Thompson St, Ann Arbor, MI 48104. [U-M campus map](#).
- **Graduate Student Instructors:** See the Canvas page.

Course Overview and Objectives

This course introduces students to the study of world politics. No prior background in world politics or international relations is assumed. Students will acquire the basic analytic tools necessary to understand and explain a variety of global phenomena including war, terrorism, globalization, environmental cooperation, international law, and human rights practices.

Course Resources

Primary Textbook

- Jeffry A. Frieden, David A. Lake, Kenneth A. Schultz, Susan D. Hyde, Stephanie J. Rickard. *World Politics: Interests, Interactions, Institutions*. 6th Edition. <https://www.norton.com/books/9781324115939>. **FLSHR** is the acronym used for this material below.
 - Jeffry A. Frieden: <https://jfrieden.scholars.harvard.edu/>
 - David A. Lake: <https://quote.ucsd.edu/lake/>

- Kenneth A. Schultz: <https://politicalscience.stanford.edu/people/kenneth-schultz>
- Susan D. Hyde: <https://hydesusan.github.io/>
- Stephanie J. Rickard: <https://www.lse.ac.uk/people/stephanie-rickard>

Additional Course Materials

- Our World In Data. <https://ourworldindata.org/>. (Selected articles). **OWD** is the acronym used for this material below.
 - Links to Bios for the Full Team: <https://ourworldindata.org/team>
- William Spaniel. "Lines on Maps." <https://www.youtube.com/@Gametheory101>. (Selected videos).
 - William Spaniel: <https://williamspaniel.com/>

Library Resources

- Contact the Political Science Librarian, Catherine Morse, for help finding relevant books, articles, and data. She can be reached at cmorse@umich.edu or you can make an appointment to meet with her online.

Introduction to R for Data Visualization (and how to use U-M GPT)

- I will introduce students to the R computing environment (<https://cran.r-project.org/>). The purpose of this introduction is to teach students how to load data into the R computing environment and then produce a graph with that data as part of the data visualization project.
- Students will need to learn how to use three functions in R for this project: `getwd()`, `read.csv()`, and `plot()` or `barplot()`. You will be able to complete the data visualization project with just these simple functions. The use of R for the Data Visualization Assignment is required.
- You may choose to use U-M GPT or another agentic coding program to create the R code for this project. **If you choose to use U-M GPT or another agentic coding program, you must submit (1) the prompt used to generate the output, (2) the specific program used, and (3) the date and time you entered the prompt.** The University of Michigan provides access to a U-M GPT tool: <https://its.umich.edu/computing/ai/gpt-in-depth>. You can read more about creating effective prompts here: <https://teamdynamix.umich.edu/TDClient/30/Portal/KB/ArticleDet?ID=10680>.
- If you are curious, I also teach a data science course that builds on these tools. You can learn more about this other course here: <https://github.com/CJFariss/Data-Science-International-Studies>. Other data science learning material is available here: <https://github.com/CJFariss/R-Program-Challenges>. Other course material is available here: <https://github.com/CJFariss/Programming-and-Simulation-Methods-for-Computational-Social-Science>.

Class Expectations and Grades

Read all assigned materials and be prepared to discuss each piece during the assigned class week. As students, we learn more when we actively engage with material instead of passively consuming it. This insight is supported by extensive research from college-level courses (<https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1821936116>). This is a large course, but we will work to actively learn together in the main lecture times and during the discussion sections.

Exams: Exams in the course are meant to allow you to demonstrate your understanding of course concepts. Exam content will consist of some combination of identification questions, essay questions, and multiple choice questions. The midterm exam will cover content from week 1 through week 7. The final exam will cover content from all weeks. Further details will be distributed in class.

- **Midterm Exam: Wednesday October 28, 4:00 pm – 5:20 pm.** The midterm exam covers content presented from Week 1 to Week 7. This is a written exam that will take place in the classroom without use of any electronic device.
- **Final Exam: Monday December 14, 4:00 pm – 6:00 pm.** The final exam covers content presented from Week 1 to Week 15. This is a written exam that will take place in the classroom without use of any electronic device.

Quizzes and Assignments: Quiz content will be available through the U-M Canvas page, during class lectures, discussion sections, and outside of class. These quizzes support several learning objectives.

- **InQuizitive Quizzes:** InQuizitive quizzes are interactive assessments that follow the textbook content. For each InQuizitive quiz, you will answer questions until you reach a specified number of points, which will then award a 100% for the weekly quiz. Complete each weekly InQuizitive quiz by the following Friday 11:59pm EST (eg., complete the week 2 InQuizitive quiz by the Friday of week 3; complete the week 3 InQuizitive quiz by the Friday of week 4; etc.). There are 15 required InQuizitive quizzes (one quiz each week). Learn more here: <https://www.norton.com/inquizitive>. Links to the textbook chapters and InQuizitive quizzes are available on the Canvas website.
- **Discussion Section Bluebook Quizzes:** Brief, in person quizzes that will be taken in person during discussion section. Blue books provided by the instructors.
- **FLSHR Check Your Understanding Boxes:** Each chapter in the textbook contains several check points for material covered in the relevant chapter. These are not required quizzes but valuable learning tools that I highly encourage students to complete. Students missing a lecture are required to complete these questions. Links to the textbook chapters are available on the Canvas website.
- **Data Visualization Assignment:** With the assistance of the instructors, identify a data visualization that captures some aspect of world politics on the <https://ourworldindata.org>

website. Recreate the visualization of this data using the program R <https://cran.r-project.org/>. Students may also use U-M GPT to assist in the re-creation of the data visualization, specifically and only for assistance with generating the required R code. On the first page of this assignment describe the dataset, a complete (not hallucinated) citation for where you obtained the data, and what the data measure. On the second page provide the data visualization itself and an informative figure caption about the data visualization. Hallucinated data, hallucinated citations, or a data visualization rendered directly from an agentic coding assistant will not be accepted as completed assignments. Additional details, instructions, and examples will be provided later in the semester.

Participation and Intellectual Engagement: This is primarily evaluated by (1) attendance to lectures and discussion sections, (2) **Discussion Section Bluebook Quizzes**, and (3) comments and questions made during lecture, section, or office hours.

- **Class and Exam Attendance.** This is an in-person class in both the lectures and the sections. Students are therefore expected to attend all of the lectures and all of the meetings of their discussion section. Students are also expected to take the midterm exam and final exam at the scheduled times. Alternate times for the midterm exam and final exam are possible only for students who can demonstrate that taking the exam at the scheduled time would impose a serious hardship on them; Professor Fariss is the final arbiter of what constitutes a serious hardship. Students who cannot take examinations at the scheduled times for medical reasons must produce a valid medical excuse from a doctor. Students who will be out of town on the day of an exam on university business must provide documentation in advance of the need to travel that day.
- **Attendance Grade Policy.** Students will not receive a penalty for missing lectures if and only if they have completed the **FLSHR Check Your Understanding Boxes** for the chapter covered during the week of a missed lecture or discussion section. Students may make up to three missed lectures or discussion sections this way without a grade reduction. Note that it is not possible to make up the **Discussion Section Bluebook Quizzes**. Additional absences are only excused with a valid medical excuse from a doctor or documentation provided in advance of the need to travel on a missed class day. Professor Fariss is the final arbiter of what constitutes a valid excuse for missing course lectures or discussion sections. Students that miss class with a validated excuse must still complete the **FLSHR Check Your Understanding Boxes** for the chapter covered during the week of a missed lecture or discussion section.

Grade Values

- Participation and Intellectual Engagement: 36 points (18 points for the first half of the semester and 18 points for the second half of the semester)

- InQuizitive Quizzes: 30 points (due weekly; assessed within one week of the Friday due date)
- Final Exam: 14 points (Monday December 14)
- Midterm Exam: 10 points (Wednesday October 28)
- Data Visualization Assignment: 10 points (due the week after Thanksgiving break)

Grade Ranges

- A+ [97+] Please note that this option is only possible under exceptional circumstances and in consultation with the instructor.
- A [93–100]
- A- [90–93)
- B+ [87–90)
- B [83–87)
- B- [80–83)
- C+ [77–80)
- C [73–77)
- C- [70–73)
- D [60–70)
- F [0–60)

Office Hours

The best way to contact me so that you can ask additional questions about course material is to attend office hours. I hold extensive office hours each week in the atrium area on the first floor of the Institute for Social Research (ISR) building, which is located at 426 Thompson St., Ann Arbor, MI 48104. Just like in the classroom, office hours sessions are designed to be an open and inclusive learning environment for my students. The ISR atrium offers an open space that accommodates small to medium size groups. There will often be more than one student seeking feedback during office hours. Each of you are welcome to join the group office hours session and ask questions or participate in discussion. I am also available outside of office hours via a message on the course management software (Canvas) or at my U-M email address: cjfariss@umich.edu. Please email but also remember that asking questions during office hours usually yields more timely and detailed responses.

Course Outline

Week 1

- **FLSHR: Introduction**
- No discussion sections this week.

Week 2

- No class on Monday in observance of the Labor Day holiday.
- **FLSHR Ch. 1:** *What Shaped Our World? A Historical Introduction*
- Discussion sections begin this week.

Week 3

- **FLSHR Ch. 2:** *Understanding Interests, Interactions, and Institutions*
- *What is an actor in world politics?*

Week 4

- **FLSHR Ch. 3:** *Why Are There Wars?*
- **OWD:** Bastian Herre, Lucas Rodés-Guirao, and Max Roser (2024) — "War and Peace." Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: <https://ourworldindata.org/war-and-peace>

Week 5

- **FLSHR Ch. 4:** *Domestic Politics and War*
- **OWD:** Bastian Herre, Lucas Rodés-Guirao, and Esteban Ortiz-Ospina (2013) - "Democracy" Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: <https://ourworldindata.org/democracy>
- U-M Library discussion.

Week 6

- **FLSHR Ch. 5:** *International Institutions and War*
- *What is a hypothesis?, What is a dependent variable?, What is an independent variable?, What do these items have to do with interest, interactions, and institutions?, What about the actors of world politics?*

Week 7

- **FLSHR Ch. 6:** *Violence by Nonstate Actors: Civil War and Terrorism*

- **OWD:** Bastian Herre, Veronika Samborska, Hannah Ritchie, and Max Roser (2023) - "Terrorism" Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: <https://ourworldindata.org/terrorism>

Week 8

- Fall break: No class on Monday or Tuesday this week.
- **FLSHR Ch. 7:** *Cross-Border Flows of Goods and Services*
- **OWD:** Esteban Ortiz-Ospina et al. (2018) — "Trade and Globalization." Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: <https://ourworldindata.org/trade-and-globalization>

Week 9

- **FLSHR Ch. 8:** *Cross-Border Flows of Money and People*
- **OWD:** Fiona Spooner et al. (2022) — "Migration." Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: <https://ourworldindata.org/migration>
- **Midterm: Wednesday October 28, 4:00 pm – 5:20 pm.** The midterm exam covers content presented from Week 1 to Week 7.

Week 10

- **FLSHR Ch. 9:** *International Monetary Relations*
- *Introduction to R and Data Visualization*

Week 11

- **FLSHR Ch. 10:** *Development: Causes of the Wealth and Poverty of Nations*
- **OWD:** Max Roser, Bertha Rohenkohl, Pablo Arriagada, Joe Hasell, Hannah Ritchie, and Esteban Ortiz-Ospina (2023) - "Economic Growth" Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: <https://ourworldindata.org/economic-growth>
- **OWD:** Joe Hasell, Bertha Rohenkohl, Pablo Arriagada, Esteban Ortiz-Ospina, and Max Roser (2023) - "Economic Inequality" Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: <https://ourworldindata.org/economic-inequality>

Week 12

- **FLSHR Ch. 11:** *International Law, Norms, and Order*

- *What is a data operationalization?*

Week 13

- Thanksgiving Break: No class on Wednesday, Thursday, or Friday this week.
- **FLSHR Ch. 12: *Human Rights***
- **OWD:** Bastian Herre and Pablo Arriagada (2016) — "Human Rights." Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: <https://ourworldindata.org/human-rights>
- No discussion sections this week.

Week 14

- **FLSHR Ch. 13: *The Global Environment***
- **OWD:** Hannah Ritchie, Pablo Rosado, and Veronika Samborska (2024) - "Climate Change" Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: <https://ourworldindata.org/climate-change>
- **Data Visualization Assignment:** Due at the end of the week. Data visualization presentations during sections this week. You will need a color printout of your data visualization during your assigned section.

Week 15

- **FLSHR Ch. 14: *Challenges to the Global Order***
- Wrap up and review

Week 16: Finals Week

- **Final Exam: Monday December 14, 4:00 pm – 6:00 pm.** The final exam covers content presented from Week 1 to Week 15.
 - U-M Final Exam Schedule: <https://ro.umich.edu/calendars/final-exams/fall-2026>
-

Additional Course Information

Academic Integrity

The LSA undergraduate academic community, like all communities, functions best when its members treat one another with honesty, fairness, respect, and trust. The College holds all members of its community to high standards of scholarship and integrity. To accomplish its mission of providing an optimal educational environment and developing leaders of society, the College promotes the assumption of personal responsibility and integrity and prohibits all forms of academic dishonesty and misconduct. Academic dishonesty may be understood as any action or attempted action that may result in creating an unfair academic advantage for oneself or an unfair academic advantage or disadvantage for any other member or members of the academic community. Conduct, without regard to motive, that violates the academic integrity and ethical standards of the College community cannot be tolerated. The College seeks vigorously to achieve compliance with its community standards of academic integrity. Violations of the standards will not be tolerated and will result in serious consequences and disciplinary action. For more information see <https://lsa.umich.edu/lsa/academics/academic-integrity.html>.

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

If you think you need an accommodation for a disability, please let me know at your earliest convenience. Some aspects of this course, the assignments, the in-class activities, and the way the course is usually taught may be modified to facilitate your participation and progress. As soon as you make me aware of your needs, we can work with the Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD) office to help us determine appropriate academic accommodations. SSD (734-763-3000; <http://ssd.umich.edu>) typically recommends accommodations through a Verified Individualized Services and Accommodations (VISA) form. Any information you provide is private and confidential and will be treated as such.

Digital Device Policy

Digital devices are not allowed during lectures without prior permission or unless otherwise indicated. During the active learning sessions that occur during discussion sections, you will need to use printed material and/or pre-drafted notes to complete any active learning tasks that we assign. We will collect the hand-written work after each class period. See the description of the **Discussion Section Bluebook Quizzes** above. If you need additional time to prepare for active learning tasks, you are invited to attend office hours for additional time.

Grade Grievances

If you believe a grade you have received is unfair or in error, you will need to do the following: Wait 24 hours after receiving the grade before approaching your instructor. Provide an explanation in writing for why the grade you received was unfair or in error. If you believe the

instructor's response fails to address your claim of unfairness or error, you may petition the department's Director of Undergraduate Studies at the latest within the first five weeks of classes following the completion of the course. You must convey in writing the basis for the complaint, with specific evidence in support of the argument that the grade either was given in error or was unfairly determined. This formal complaint also should summarize the outcome of the initial inquiry to the course instructor, indicating which aspects are in dispute. Within three weeks of the receipt of the petition, the DUS will determine whether to convene the Undergraduate Affairs Committee, the student, and the instructor(s) for a formal hearing. Further details on this process are included on the department website under Advising > Contesting a Grade.

Language and Gender

"Language is gender-inclusive and non-sexist when we use words that affirm and respect how people describe, express, and experience their gender. Just as sexist language excludes women's experiences, non-gender-inclusive language excludes the experiences of individuals whose identities may not fit the gender binary, and/or who may not identify with the sex they were assigned at birth. Identities including trans, intersex, and genderqueer reflect personal descriptions, expressions, and experiences. Gender-inclusive/non-sexist language acknowledges people of any gender (for example, first year student versus freshman, chair versus chairman, humankind versus mankind, etc.). It also affirms non-binary gender identifications, and recognizes the difference between biological sex and gender expression. Teachers and students should use gender-inclusive words and language whenever possible in the classroom and in writing. *Students, faculty, and staff may share their preferred pronouns and names, either to the class or privately to the professor, and these gender identities and gender expressions should be honored.*" For more information:

<https://www.wstudies.pitt.edu/faculty/gender-inclusivenon-sexist-language-syllabi-statement>.

Religious and Academic Conflicts

Although the University of Michigan, as an institution, does not observe religious holidays, it has long been the University's policy that every reasonable effort should be made to help students avoid negative academic consequences when their religious obligations conflict with academic requirements. Absence from classes or examinations for religious reasons does not relieve students from responsibility for any part of the course work required during the period of absence. Students who expect to miss classes, examinations, or other assignments as a consequence of their religious observance shall be provided with a reasonable alternative opportunity to complete such academic responsibilities.

It is the obligation of students to provide faculty with reasonable notice of the dates of religious holidays on which they will be absent. Such notice must be given by the drop/add deadline of the given term. Students who are absent on days of examinations or class assignments shall be offered an opportunity to make up the work, without penalty, unless it can be demonstrated that a make-up opportunity would interfere unreasonably with the delivery of the course. Should

disagreement arise over any aspect of this policy, the parties involved should contact the Director of Undergraduate Studies/Director of Graduate Studies. Final appeals will be resolved by the Provost.

Resources for Harassment

Title IX makes it clear that violence and harassment based on sex and gender, including violence and harassment based on sexual orientation, are a Civil Rights offense subject to the same kinds of accountability and the same kinds of support applied to offenses against other protected categories such as race, national origin, etc. For information about help and resources at University of Michigan please contact the Sexual Assault Prevention and Awareness Center (SAPAC): <https://sapac.umich.edu/SupportServices>; (734) 764-7771; sapac@umich.edu. For information about filing a report or complaint with the Title IX office at the University of Michigan see <https://sexualmisconduct.umich.edu/reporting-process/reporting-to-the-university/>. Please note that Title IX offices often distinguish between making a report, which does not launch an investigation, and filing a complaint, which does launch an investigation.

Student Mental Health and Wellbeing

University of Michigan is committed to advancing the mental health and wellbeing of its students. If you or someone you know is feeling overwhelmed, depressed, and/or in need of support, services are available. For help, contact Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS) at (734) 764-8312 and <https://caps.umich.edu/> during and after hours, on weekends and holidays, or through its counselors physically located in schools on both North and Central Campus.

Students Representing the University of Michigan

There may be instances when students must miss class due to their commitment to officially represent the University. These students may be involved in the performing arts, scientific or artistic endeavors, or intercollegiate athletics. Absence from classes while representing the University does not relieve students from responsibility for any part of the course missed during the period of absence. Students should provide reasonable notice for dates of anticipated absences and submit an individualized class excuse form.